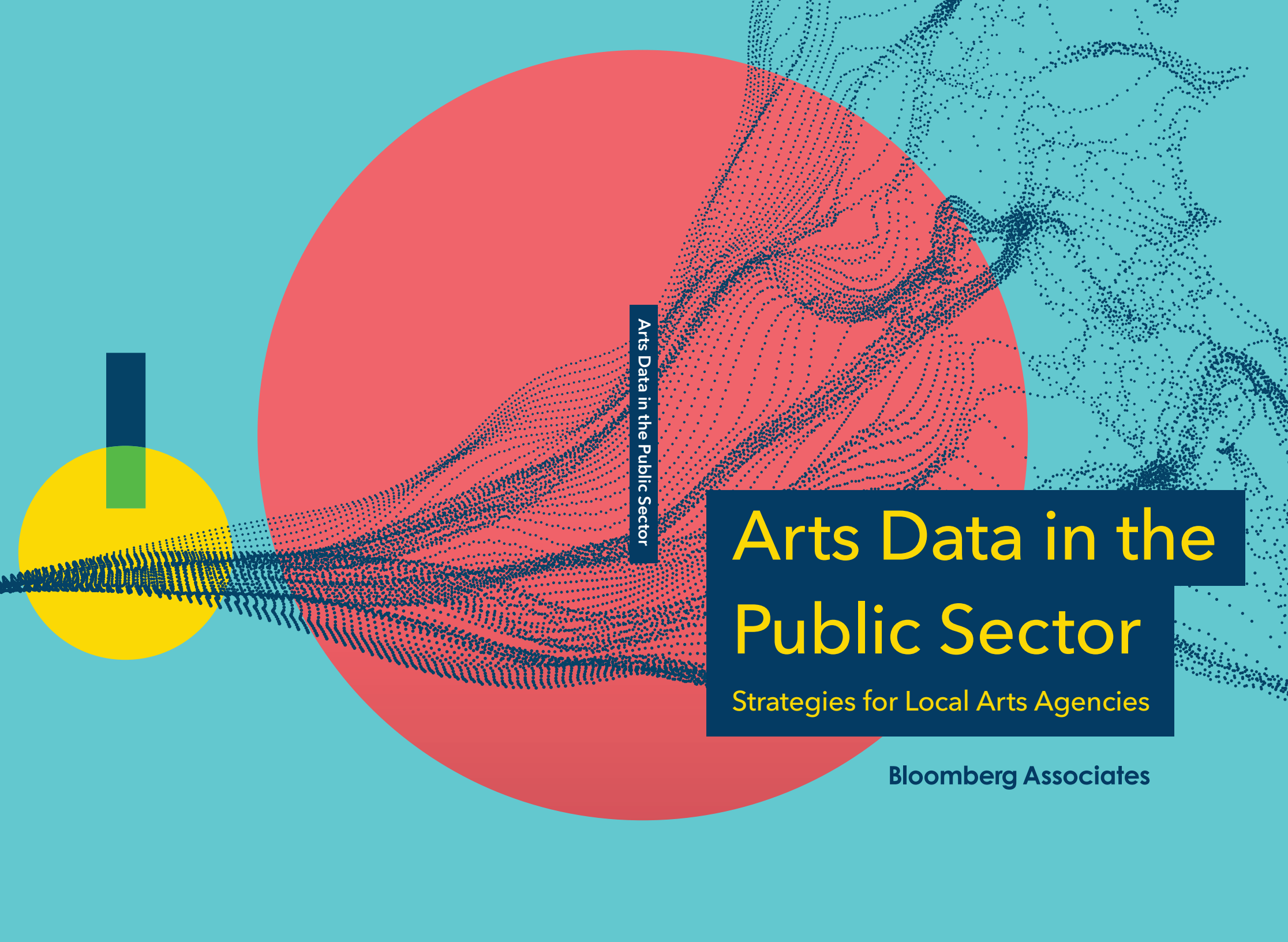




Arts Data in the Public Sector

Arts Data in the Public Sector

Strategies for Local Arts Agencies

Bloomberg Associates

INTRODUCTION

Cities are increasingly using data to help shape policy and identify service gaps. With the Covid-19 pandemic and intensifying demand for equity, we believe the desire for reliable, longitudinal information will only increase in the coming years as municipalities with severely limited resources face critical decisions in trying to “build back better.”

The trend toward data-informed decision-making poses challenges as well as opportunities for government agencies serving the nonprofit arts and cultural sector. Challenges, because of the long-standing difficulties in identifying meaningful metrics that capture quality as well as quantity in this unique field. As the saying goes, “not everything that can be counted counts.” Opportunities, because the move toward putting funding applications online, along with increasingly robust data sets in related areas, makes it possible to approach cultural analytics in increasingly strategic and nuanced ways.

So how can cities leverage arts data to:

- **better serve grantees?**
- **promote equity in service delivery?**
- **fulfill regulatory requirements for tax-levy funding?**
- **track Covid-19-related changes in the local creative sector?**
- **demonstrate the impact of arts and culture across a range of significant policy priorities?**

These questions surfaced frequently in our client engagements with U.S. cities even before the pandemic because there is inconsistent information available about data collection by local arts agencies. Often there is reticence around data efforts, which is understandable given proprietary concerns about grant applications and reports – the primary sources of local data collection – and funding practices that are necessarily specific to each locality. But with increasing urgency around understanding the impact of government support for nonprofit culture, and the innovative work being done in many localities, the topic is timely and ripe for exploration.

In an attempt to help fill this information gap, we embarked on extensive sector research and supplemented it with deep-dive looks at the data practices of fifteen local arts agencies across the country to capture a meaningful cross-section of constituencies, resources, and strategies. These agencies range in size, location, and purview, and together they provide a useful array of data practices that demonstrate different but often complementary approaches to common objectives. Our research focused primarily on grantmaking data, though some agencies collect useful data related to their other work, such as public art and arts education.

This Guide summarizes our findings, sharing best practices and identifying areas of ongoing complexity and potential. The Guide is far from comprehensive, and won't be applicable to every agency's funding structure or local political landscape. But our goal is to offer useful insights and practical resources that can assist and inspire local government arts funders and advocates as they work both in the near term to emerge from the pandemic and in the longer term to establish more equitable and inclusive practices and to affirm the importance of arts and culture as a public service well into the future.

CONTEXT

Prior to the pandemic, the country's local arts agencies (as many as 4,500, as estimated by Americans for the Arts) collectively invested \$2.8 billion in nonprofit culture each year, including \$600 million of direct investment through grants, contracts, and loans. This makes local public funding one of the biggest sources of support for the arts in the U.S.¹ By way of comparison, the other key funding pillars have been states (\$300 million)², the federal government (\$100 million)³, and private foundations (\$4 billion)⁴.

The mission and program areas of local arts agencies differ, but most often include funding for arts groups, community organizations, individual artists, and a range of initiatives that make the arts accessible to communities of all kinds.

The structure and size of these agencies vary as well. Some are positioned within government as departments or department subdivisions, while others are

independent nonprofit organizations tasked with providing services to local governments.

In addition to structural variety, arts agencies differ in their data collection practices. Our approach in compiling this Guide has been to respect these many differences, while focusing on the most commonly shared elements of structure and process.

Regardless of their differences, since March 2020 all fifteen cities we researched were faced with the urgent and overpowering crisis of the Covid-19 pandemic. Many relied on existing data about their communities in order to respond appropriately, and, in the course of their relief efforts, many collected further data to understand the severity of the impact on the field. Having a reliable system for collecting and analyzing data (and having certain data already on hand) allowed many agencies to provide relief efforts in an efficient and targeted manner that was invaluable at a time when many arts organizations were facing financial disaster.

LOCAL ARTS AGENCIES INCLUDED IN THIS GUIDE



- | | | |
|--|---|--|
| 1. Arts & Science Council of Charlotte-Mecklenburg | 6. City of Phoenix Office of Arts & Culture | 11. Nashville Metro Arts |
| 2. Arts Council New Orleans | 7. Cuyahoga Arts & Culture (Cleveland) | 12. New York City Department of Cultural Affairs |
| 3. Austin Cultural Arts Division | 8. Denver Arts & Venues | 13. Philadelphia Cultural Fund |
| 4. Boston Mayor's Office of Arts & Culture | 9. Houston Mayor's Office of Cultural Affairs | 14. San Francisco Arts Commission |
| 5. Chicago Department of Cultural Affairs and Special Events | 10. Los Angeles County Department of Arts & Culture | 15. Seattle Office of Arts & Culture |

"Data is critically important to us – for better understanding the audiences we serve, for making strategic and tactical decisions, and for sharing the community impact of our cultural grants and other programs."

Mark Kelly, Commissioner (2016-2021), Chicago Department of Cultural Affairs and Special Events

¹"Equitable Investment Policies and Practices in the Local Arts Field," Clayton Lord, Americans for the Arts, 2019. ²"State Arts Agency Grantmaking and Funding," National Assembly of State Arts Agencies, 2017. ³"2017 Annual Report," National Endowment for the Arts, 2018. ⁴"Not Just Money," Helicon Collaborative, 2018.

COMMON CONCERNS

While no two agencies have identical practices, the four following points – from philosophical to pragmatic – were consistently cited in framing the complexities of government data collection in the arts:

The Case for Culture

Benchmarking standardized service delivery is usually considered a hallmark of effective government; however, this practice doesn't easily apply to arts and culture, a field in which variety and differentiation are central. Reducing arts impacts to numbers risks losing the essential value of creative work, but there may be a greater risk of having the cultural field excluded altogether from civic policymaking in the absence of meaningful metrics.

Counting What Counts

Enumerating some aspects of the arts is not necessarily difficult – e.g., number of programs, artists involved, attendance, prices, etc. However, the metrics that can be easily collected are often unreliable in predicting short- or long-term cultural value. A common through line is that a focus on “popularity” is felt to run counter to artistic innovation. And some of the greatest civic benefits of having a robust creative sector – for the economy, safety, education, and public health – require additional, more complex data to adequately assess.

“What data is the magic data? And what can we afford to spend in order to collect it and turn it into something?”

Barbara Silzle, Executive Director, Philadelphia Cultural Fund

Uniforms for Unicorns

Even with robust data in hand, the diversity of arts activities can make it a challenge to reconcile numbers and outcomes across the sector. For example, saying that one arts activity served 10 people while another served 1,000 implies that the latter activity was 100x more impactful than the former. However, if the first activity was a semester-long dance intensive and the second activity was a single-day festival, value and impact are exceptionally hard to compare. As a result, within the field, data is often perceived as being secondary to the art and, at worst, a means of undermining it.

Resources for Results

Public funding entities are often under pressure to justify internal expenses that pull resources away from direct support of arts groups. So finding effective, low-cost strategies for extracting value from data – without overtaxing already stretched staff and budgets – can be an ongoing struggle.

PRIORITIES

The local arts agency leadership we interviewed were strongly aligned around the following four priorities when making decisions about data collection, all of which were amplified during the Covid-19 crisis:

Compliance

What information needs to be collected and reviewed to ensure compliance with all regulatory and oversight functions required for public funding?

The rich variety of cultural activities is a strength, but tracking delivery of many different kinds of funded services can require a range of strategies.

Field Knowledge

What data is most helpful in gaining and sharing a deeper understanding of the local arts sector?

Segmenting information by categories that help reflect the overall sector is essential, and the most reliable informational building blocks are artistic discipline, budget size, and location(s) of service delivery.

Tracking specific categories over time can yield important information about sector health, including trends in programming and management.

Advocacy

What actionable datasets can speed understanding of timely issues and garner more resources?

Ease of producing meaningful information in shareable form is essential to making the case for nonprofit culture when working with elected officials and private-sector funders.

Data broken down into targeted segments can garner support for audience development, partnerships, and other new initiatives, and, critically, it can also help make the case for new or expanded funding.

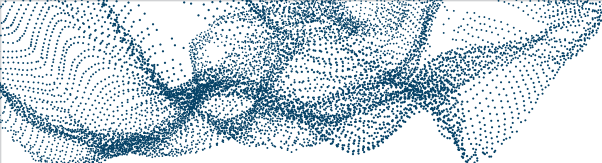
Equity

What data is essential to assessing the equitable access to public funding?

Capturing geographic and demographic reach of service delivery can reveal successes and gaps in funding processes, distribution of investments across communities, and other issues that would benefit from deeper analysis and, in many cases, changes in policy.

“With Bloomberg Associates’ help in 2019, we created for the first time a heat-map showing how our programs are reaching all 35 Nashville City Council districts. This is a simple thing, but enormously impactful in advocating for our annual operating budget allocation.”

Caroline Vincent, Executive Director, Nashville Metro Arts



COLLECT

The current state of data collection runs the gamut from user-friendly digital technologies to exclusively paper-based methods. Some local arts agencies use both, such as an online application form with supplementary materials collected in hard copy. Among the fifteen agencies we interviewed, the most common mechanisms for collecting data are:

- **Grant Applications:**
Typically submitted annually in advance of the grant cycle (projected data about programs).
- **Final Reports:**
Typically collected annually at the end of the grant cycle (data about programs will be actual).
- **SMU DataArts:**
Roughly 75 grantmakers and service organizations nationwide use this system, which offers the additional benefit of comparative benchmarking across localities. (See page 17 for more information on SMU DataArts.)

A handful of agencies we spoke to also collect data through surveys or forms requested at various points during the grant cycle or at particular inflection points or moments of crisis. Some agencies also supplement with data from external sources (e.g., U.S. Census; local university research) regarding their cities' cultural producers and participants.

Common Challenge | Asking the Right Questions in the Right Format

- How to build applications and reports with data collection goals in mind. Reviewing and adjusting questions regularly can help ensure the most useful data is being solicited in the most efficient format.
- How to balance collecting necessary information while minimizing the burden on grantees to do tracking and data entry that may divert focus from an organization's programming and management goals.

(See page 13 for more information on designing data-friendly application and reporting questions.)

Questions to Consider:

- What information is needed...
 - to meet regulatory oversight responsibilities?
 - about grantees and agency impact to build an understanding of the local cultural sector?
 - on behalf of external parties like city government colleagues, elected officials, grantees, arts funders, stakeholders?
 - to respond quickly in a time of crisis (e.g., natural or financial disaster, public health emergency)?
- Which data points, alone or in the aggregate, can deliver the answers required?
- How burdensome is it for applicants and grantees to provide that information?
- What question formats or reporting platforms can make it easier for agency staff to analyze information, and reduce the need for redundant data entry?
- Are there other existing datasets that already collect some of this information, and can they be easily accessed?
- Are there any privacy concerns that must be addressed when collecting certain data, such as staff demographics?

Data-Friendly Application & Reporting Questions

Several key steps surfaced repeatedly in our interviews around the process of becoming more “data-friendly”:

- Assessing existing applications, reports, surveys, and other data collection mechanisms to gauge if the data being requested is actually what the agency wants and is reasonable for organizations to provide. For example, an agency may want numerical demographic breakdowns of audience, but that may be infeasible if not all applicants are able to provide comprehensive and accurate figures. In that case, requesting alternative data – such as audience zip codes – may be less nuanced but still relevant and easier to collect. Or, if the data is essential, ensure that applicants have the necessary tools and training available to them to support their data collection efforts.
- Designing questions to enable standardized responses allows for easier data analysis. Favored tactics include replacing short text fields with dropdown lists or isolating key data points out from narrative fields. For example, if the number of staff members is a key data point, an agency might ask for that number to be entered in its own field, rather than having to manually tally up a staff list.
- Evaluating which data is necessary for application review and which is better collected through a final report – streamlines the process for everyone involved. Information that may be useful for research efforts but isn’t necessary for making funding decisions can be solicited as part of a later reporting process for grantees or a light-touch field survey. But asking for too much data in an application can unduly burden organizations that may never benefit from public funding, as well as the assessment work of staff and/or outside panelists.
- Providing clear, comprehensive instructional text is essential to receiving meaningful data. For example, when asking for staff numbers, it is important to clarify whether the request is only for full-time employees or a combination of full-time, part-time, and volunteers. As another example, in the case of a film series with ten screenings, there should be no confusion about whether this is reported as one program or ten.

(See “Data Categories” on page 45 for considerations and sample questions.)

Collecting Data During a Crisis

Data has proven to be especially valuable in times of crisis for cities to act swiftly to support artists and organizations in need. With the emergence of the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020, local arts agencies around the country employed different strategies for collecting and utilizing data to help them provide emergency relief support in various forms.

Methods of Collection: Some agencies issued surveys of their applicants or grantees to assess the impact of Covid-19 on their finances, employment, and programming. Others incorporated such questions into application or reporting forms for existing grant programs or new emergency relief funds. Many agencies also made use of national data collection efforts by various research firms and service organizations.

Advocacy Efforts: Several agencies reported using data collected about the impact of Covid-19 on artists and arts organizations to make a case for the dire situation that the creative sector was in and to advocate for allocations from

relief funding or to block proposed budget cuts. In one example, the Los Angeles County Department of Arts & Culture (LACDAC) surveyed its grantee organizations and used the statistic that 83% planned to spend at least a portion of their relief funds on payroll to make the case that this support would be a significant investment in the art workforce.

Distribution of Relief Funds: Several agencies used existing or newly collected data to inform their distribution of available local and national relief funds. Chicago’s Department of Cultural Affairs and Special Events used data about organizations’ staff, facilities, assets, and financial loss due to Covid-19 to determine “need tiers” for distributing CARES Act funds. The NYC Department of Cultural Affairs leveraged its existing location-based funding process to allocate additional funds to organizations working in low-income neighborhoods and those most affected by Covid-19.

“In the early months of the pandemic, I recommended against conducting yet another survey at a time when our arts community was struggling to survive. But when LA County set aside \$12M in CARES Act funds to distribute to nonprofit arts organizations, we used the grant application process as an opportunity to collect data on both losses and unanticipated expenses due to Covid.”

Bronwyn Mauldin, Director of Research and Evaluation, LACDAC

Collection Methods

The online collection methods of local arts agencies vary, but fall into three main types, each with strengths and weaknesses:

1. Editable file

- (e.g., PDF or Microsoft Word)
- Easy to create, use, and share
- Work can be saved and returned to later

BUT

- Often requires data to be manually extracted and entered into agency database

2. Basic online form (e.g., form created through Google, Submittable, or Survey Monkey)

- Easy to create and use
- Data automatically populates a database

BUT

- Often has to be filled out all at once
- Might not provide data in an easily readable view for panel/staff review or applicants' records

3. Customized grant portal

- Often allows applicants to create a unique account where they can access information related to their applications and grants, including previously submitted forms
- Work can be saved and returned to later
- Often lets agency create customized views/datasets for ease of review, aggregation, and analysis

BUT

- Costly to purchase or develop
- Often requires significant technical support, both for agency staff and for applicants

“Our Programming Location Report is a simple worksheet that allows our grantees to track where CAC-supported programs and events took place When combined, it provides a comprehensive picture of our impact – we can create a map of the public dollars we invest and see right away how they are reaching residents in neighborhoods across our service area.”

Jill M. Paulsen, Executive Director, Cuyahoga Arts & Culture

Program Locations

Many agencies have begun collecting addresses of program sites in addition to administrative addresses, with a mind toward making maps of funded programs. While this is more work for an applicant organization if it has multiple programming sites, this kind of reporting can provide a much more accurate depiction of where funded activities are taking place than mapping only headquarters. (See page 58 for a representative map comparison)

A common method of collecting program addresses is using a Microsoft Excel spreadsheet that is submitted along with reporting requirements. This method requires agency staff to compile all of the submitted spreadsheets into a single dataset, and may require further cleaning of the data before inputting it into Google Maps or other mapping software.

(See page 57 for considerations about collecting Program Location data.)

Program Locations Spreadsheet

Nashville Metro Arts uses its “Project Locations and Participation Report” to collect useful data about the locations of its funded programs, including the type of facility, number of occurrences of the program, and number of participants. This data is then used for mapping purposes, both internally and also made public on Nashville’s Open Data portal.

Organization								
Fiscal Year								
Please list all physical addresses (no P.O. boxes) where any project activities have taken place during the project time frame. This helps us identify where all arts and culture activities are happening across Davidson County and how many people are participating in the arts. Thank you in advance for helping us tell this compelling story!								
Grant Category	Location Name	Location Type	Street Address	City	State	Zip Code	# Occurrences	# Participants

SMU Data Arts

Many of the agencies we interviewed partner with Southern Methodist University (SMU) DataArts, a national arts research center that collects in-depth data about arts nonprofits across the country. In a typical partnership, agencies require their applicants to complete SMU DataArts' Cultural Data Profile (CDP) with information about their organizational structure, finances, and programs. In return, agencies have access to all of the data their applicants have submitted, and the applicants get access to aggregate data about the sector as well as tools to use for benchmarking purposes and to identify internal trends over time.

Before adding the CDP as a requirement, some agencies have first assessed how many of their grantees already complete the CDP annually, and, for those that don't, how much work it would be for their staff to start. Agencies have also assessed their own application and reporting forms and determined if there are duplicative sections that can be removed after adoption of the CDP.

(See the chart on page 67 for more information about the data categories collected by SMU DataArts.)

INTERPRET

Interpreting data, once it has been collected, can require a significant investment of staff time. The core analytical focus of a local arts agency needs to be on whatever is necessary for its application review process to fulfill its funding mandate. But integrating data analysis into year-round workstreams has been prioritized by the fifteen agencies we interviewed, with meaningful outcomes. In addition to impact evaluation, these entities share an interest in assessing distribution of funding across their cities, both geographically and demographically.

Common Challenge | Sufficient Staff Time and Expertise

- How to cultivate internal capacity within agencies that generally have slim staffs whose expertise is grants management and nonprofit administration, not necessarily evaluation. One successful strategy is to foster in-house skills-building in combination with engaging other city/county resources or external research partners to assist with more comprehensive data analysis.
- How to mesh deep staff knowledge of the local creative sector with data-driven assessment. Some of the agencies we interviewed acknowledge a tension between invaluable on-the-ground experience and metrics that may seem counterintuitive or lacking nuance. Working toward a productive alignment in which staff expertise is reinforced and extended by data can be time-consuming, but is increasingly essential in developing new programs (e.g., by identifying gaps in service) and advocating for additional funding (e.g., by sharing the economic or social impact of the arts).

Questions to Consider:

- What are the best moments in an agency's annual workstream to allocate time for data analysis beyond what is required for application review and final reporting compliance?
- How can agency leadership prioritize and develop evaluation competencies as part of existing staff responsibilities? Is there a staff person who can be designated as the full-time "owner" of grantee data analytics?
- What other municipal resources may be accessible, for example, through an Open Data initiative?
- Are private-sector partnerships – for example, via a local university internship – a viable option for accessing dependable expertise?
- Are national research efforts helpful in providing impact frameworks and/or supplementary data analytics? (e.g., SMU DataArts, National Endowment for the Arts, Americans for the Arts, or the U.S. Census)

■ Baseline Analysis of Grantee Data

Establishing a robust baseline for each metric is essential to useful data interpretation. Without context, information in an area as nuanced as nonprofit culture may be misleading. For example, a drop in organizational revenue could signal an increase in free programming rather than fiscal stress.

Some agencies we interviewed spoke about the challenges of retrospectively constructing a baseline; several said they succeeded by doing it in increments, starting with a limited number of categories and building out over a few years. All found the effort to be worthwhile, illuminating trends and shifts in the grantee pool that can guide outreach efforts, technical assistance, and advocacy for additional funds. In addition, this kind of data can drive participation in policy conversations involving economic development, tourism, and other long-lead areas of civic interest.

(See page 48 for more information on Data Categories.)

The most common elements of baseline data analysis:

1. Overview of Grant Pool:

- Number of applicants
- Number of grantees
- Amounts awarded
- Can be further categorized by:
 - Artistic discipline
 - Organizational budget size
 - Administrative or programmatic locations or other neighborhood data

2. Program Information

- Number of activities funded
- Number of attendees/participants reached
- Number of program hours
- Demographics of attendees/participants (depending on mission, may analyze race, age, gender, disability status, etc.)
- Ticket prices
- Can be further cross-referenced with:
 - Organizational budget size
 - Artistic discipline
 - Administrative or programmatic locations
 - Demographics of attendees/participants

3. Facility Information

- Facility type (e.g., museum, school, senior center, office space)
- Facility status (e.g., owned, rented, donated)
- Hours open to the public
- Square footage
- Accessibility to people with disabilities
- Can be further cross-referenced with:
 - Organizational budget size
 - Artistic discipline
 - Administrative or programmatic locations

4. Workforce & Leadership Information

- Number of staff (and whether full- or part-time)
- Number of board members
- Number of artists (and % paid)
- Number of volunteers
- Demographics of staff, board, and leadership
- Can be further categorized by:
 - Organizational budget size
 - Artistic discipline
 - Administrative or programmatic locations
 - Demographics of attendees/participants

5. Program Locations

- Presence of program sites in each zip code, neighborhood, or other geographic unit
- Number of activities, participants, and/or program hours at each site
- Can be further cross-referenced with:
 - Organizational budget size
 - Artistic discipline
 - Number of attendees/participants
 - Facility type (particularly non-arts venues)
 - Ticket prices

■ Overlaying Complementary Data

Many local arts agencies turn to existing external datasets to deepen their understanding of constituent needs and impact. Among the fifteen agencies we interviewed, the most common external data sources were SMU DataArts, the U.S. Census, and, when available, their city's Open Data platform. Some have also utilized the Urban Institute's National Center for Charitable Statistics to access publicly available IRS 990 data.

The most successful use of this strategy is typically through place-based analyses, literally mapping grantee information alongside complementary neighborhood data get a more nuanced view of how funded programs serve the city's communities and residents. While these efforts don't substitute for information collected by cultural organizations about their actual attendees, this use of data can offer helpful perspectives on the networking effect of culture and the value of the arts to local development projects.

"Gathering program locations from all the grantees creates a powerful dataset. You can marry that data with important community metrics."

Neville Vakharia, Board Member,
Philadelphia Cultural Fund

The two main strategies that have been productive:

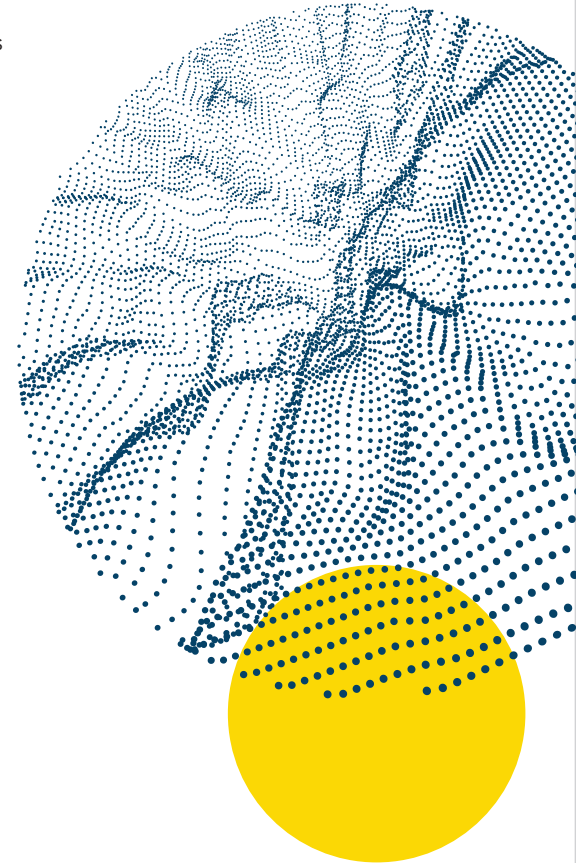
1. Participation: Looking at the locations of funded programs by neighborhood side by side with demographic or socioeconomic information about the populations in those neighborhoods for insights into attendance and access.

- Program location does not indicate where attendees may be traveling from, but this strategy can still generate insights into the likely beneficiaries of programming, especially for activities that are community-focused.
- Agencies that fund programs for public school students may find value in utilizing available data (such as race/ethnicity or eligibility for free lunch) to get a better understanding of the student populations being served and how cultural programming may be aligned with educational goals and policies.
- When available, some agencies make use of street address lists of organizations' subscribers or program participants (anonymized for privacy purposes) to get mappable participation data that can be overlaid with complementary datasets.

2. Partnerships: Looking at the locations of grant programs alongside other neighborhood assets, such as parks, libraries, or community centers.

- These kinds of overlays can help document existing partnerships as well as suggest important new opportunities to leverage public realm programming, which can provide a sense of existing and potential partnerships outside the arts sector and cross-collaborations among sectors.

(See "Census Data Analysis" Case Study on page 23)



Census Data Analysis

Agency: Los Angeles County Department of Arts and Culture (LACDAC)

Catalyst: In 2015, LACDAC piloted a new grant program for non-arts nonprofits that have arts programs, with the dual goals of: making arts services available to residents who might not experience them through traditional arts venues and encouraging the intersection of the arts in cross-sector work in local nonprofits.

Goal: LACDAC needed a way to compare the new program against its flagship program and answer the question of whether it had reached different communities. If the answer turned out to be yes, a strong argument could be made for extending and expanding the pilot program.

Process: LACDAC created a new “community reach” metric by overlaying zip codes of grantee headquarters (and later of all service locations, not just headquarters) with U.S. Census data about race/ethnicity and socioeconomic status, downloaded from the Census (data.census.gov). For each grant program, they calculated what percent of grantees were headquartered in zip codes where the population was majority Latinx, majority African American, majority Asian American, or majority White. They calculated what percent of grantees were headquartered in zip codes where more than a quarter of the population lived in poverty, and what percent were headquartered in zip codes where the median household income was lower than the countywide median.

Zip code tables used from the Census:

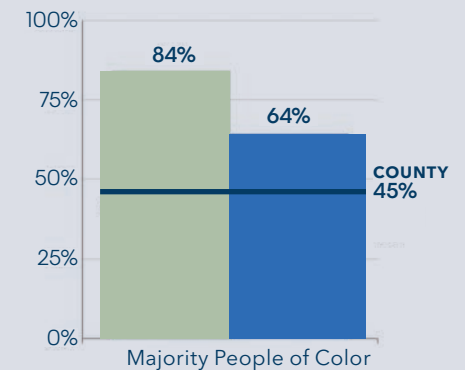
- Percent of residents in each zip code for each of the major Census race and ethnicity categories
- Percent of residents in each zip code living in poverty
- Median household income for residents in each zip code

Findings:

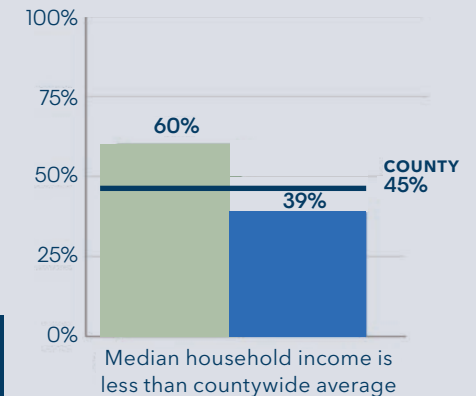
- Both programs’ grantees provided services in more zip codes where the majority of residents are people of color (in particular Latinx residents) than the countywide average.
- Between the two programs, the new program’s grantees served more zip codes where the majority of residents are people of color, as well as in zip codes where most residents earn lower than the countywide median household income.
- Nearly a quarter of the zip codes served by the new program’s grantees were zip codes that the flagship program did not serve at all.

■ New Program
■ Flagship Program

Grantee-served zip codes with majority people of color



Grantee-served zip codes with low median household income



Outcome: LACDAC used this research to successfully advocate for increased funding for its new program: in 2018, the County Board of Supervisors extended the program for an additional three years with a 50% increase in funding (from \$500,000 to \$750,000 per year), and, in 2021, the Board voted to budget it as an ongoing program after six years as a demonstration project.

“We’re using this research to advocate for a program that has turned out to be remarkably successful in achieving its goals of reaching communities that historically have not had as much exposure or access to nonprofit arts programming.”

Bronwyn Mauldin, Director of Research and Evaluation, LACDAC

Cultural Facilities Fund

Agency: Seattle Office of Arts & Culture

Catalyst: In 2017, the Seattle Office of Arts & Culture was allocated additional funds to expand its Capital Facilities Fund from \$250,000 to \$1,000,000.

Goal: The agency utilized the Racial Equity Toolkit model designed by the Seattle Race and Social Justice Initiative to ensure that the additional funds were being distributed in a racially equitable way.

Process: Through a mix of paper and online surveys, interviews, and group sessions, the agency engaged the cultural community around how to encourage more organizations of color to apply. From this community engagement came a series of recommendations for structural changes to the application, panel review, and funding processes. Many of the recommendations were implemented, including broadening the eligibility criteria to allow for new kinds of applicants (e.g., unincorporated nonprofit organizations, for-profit community venues) and projects (e.g., planning projects, post-build equipment purchases).

Outcome: The program went from 28% of its funding going to organizations of color to 76% ("of color" being determined by racial and/or ethnic composition of leadership and of constituency served).

"Data isn't always numbers listed in a spreadsheet.

Often the valuable data is in the subjective, anecdotal, relationship-based conversations we can have with cultural communities. It's then up to us, as policy strategists, to aggregate that community input into actionable "data" and design programmatic responses to community's needs."

Matthew Richter, Cultural Space Liaison, Seattle Arts Commission

Eligibility Criteria

Applicant pool analysis can help identify specific eligibility criteria that may be challenging to meet. This could be supplemented by gathering information about potential applicants from underrepresented communities through surveys, interviews, or group conversations.

Arts agencies that are a part of local governments have strict requirements about what kinds of entities and programming can receive public funding, so it may not be possible to remove some of these barriers. However, in some cases, municipal arts agencies have been given legal dispensation to adjust matching requirements for smaller grants, or accept applications from unincorporated entities through a fiscal sponsor. Some agencies have developed long-term contracts with cultural nonprofits to administer dedicated regranteeing programs to reach a wider network of artists and entities that may not be eligible to receive direct government funds.

It can be extremely helpful to understand the role of certain criteria in limiting an agency's ability to distribute funding. And, since the point of data collection is to provide actionable insights, identifying a significant constituency that is not currently served by government may offer an opportunity for a reassessment of the agency's eligibility criteria or may help focus private-sector resources or otherwise drive new partnerships that benefit stakeholders.

Key elements that local arts agencies have screened for include:

1. Organizational Criteria

- Nonprofit incorporation and/or 501(c)3 status
- Number of years in operation
- Location of administrative headquarters and/or primary programming
- Religious or political affiliation

2. Budget Criteria

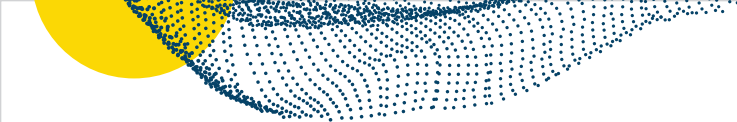
- Organizational budget size
- Number of years receiving public funds
- Percentage required to be matched by other funding sources

3. Programmatic Criteria

- Types of eligible activities
- Required insurance coverage for activities

"National data shows that artists and arts groups from Black, Indigenous, and people of color (BIPOC) communities are primarily supported by members of those communities, and, unfortunately, they often have fewer resources for private philanthropy, so the matching requirement could be tough for them."

Jesús Pantel, Contract Management Specialist, Austin Cultural Arts Division



SHARE

Local arts agencies have long been repositories of crucial data about arts and culture in the U.S. However, many have not had the tools or motivation to share that information and any corresponding analysis back to the field, though organizations like Americans for the Arts have worked to assist these efforts for decades. Making this data public not only helps establish or reinforce the leadership provided by local arts agencies, but can also be of enormous value to a broad range of stakeholders, from equipping legislators with tools to advocate for cultural funding to empowering arts organizations to benchmark against their peers.

Common Challenge | Access to Tools and Technology

- How to access effective data-sharing tools, such as visualization software that may be part of a citywide software license and not otherwise available to individual agencies.
- How to ensure staff has access to adequate training when tools are available.

Questions to Consider:

- Does the agency have a mechanism for sharing data publicly?
- What data will be most valuable to different audiences? (e.g., grantees, elected officials, private funders, researchers)
- Have the data collection systems been designed for maximum ease of extracting and sharing information?
- Is the way the data is visualized telling the most effective and accurate story?
- How does the agency deal with grantee concerns about privacy and proprietary information?
- Does the city have an Open Data platform? What about GIS or other mapping technology?

Mapping

Both static and interactive mapping are increasingly popular among arts agencies and can be customized for different audiences (e.g., mapping grantees and cultural venues in a particular neighborhood for local elected officials). Two common options are in use:

Google Maps can be used to generate a free, interactive map from a spreadsheet of addresses. This tool is relatively easy to use and, while it can support fairly elaborate features like pop-up boxes, the required dataset is very basic:

- Street address
- City
- Zip code

Additional information often added via the spreadsheet includes:

- Grantee name
- Artistic discipline
- Program name
- Facility name and/or type
- Number of participants/attendees
- Number of days/occurrences

GIS mapping tools are used in many cities, and local arts agencies have had some success in creating internal partnerships to access these tools for use in visualizing cultural data. This proprietary software may require some training to use, but can produce highly sophisticated maps and layer complex datasets from other sources. Some Open Data platforms have mapping tools embedded.

(See the section on collecting location data on page 57 for considerations and challenges of mapping arts data.)

“The data we capture does not only support our internal efforts, but supports our agency “storytelling.” As a social and cultural enterprise, we can tell an inspiring and powerful story of how we invest in the community and how community members are also investing in our programs through their participation.”

Tariana Navas-Nieves, Director of Cultural Affairs, Denver Arts & Venues

This section offers a deeper dive into the categories of data that local arts agencies commonly collect about their grantee organizations, unpacking options and issues around each data point. It was developed through a comprehensive materials review of the fifteen agencies that so generously shared information with us, including applications and reporting forms. We also reviewed SMU DataArts' Cultural Data Profile, which is utilized by over half of the agencies we interviewed.

Our goal here is to identify the data points most commonly requested and most easily aggregated. By no means a definitive or recommended data collection model, this should serve as a reference for local arts agencies in developing and refining their practices.

The section is organized into five subject areas, with accompanying considerations about collecting, interpreting, and sharing the associated data:

1. Organizational Profile (Page 48)

General information about the organization, including its budget and facilities
2. Workforce & Leadership (Page 51)

Information about the organization's staff, board, artists, and volunteers
3. Programming (Page 53)

Basic information about the organization's activities and attendees/participants
4. Locations (Page 57)

Administrative and programmatic addresses, as well as key information about those venues
5. Demographics (Page 61)

Information about the populations that make up the organization's staff, board, artists, and attendees/participants

ORGANIZATIONAL PROFILE

General information about grantee organizations can be helpful for understanding the kinds of organizations that are and aren't applying for funding, and how they fare in the funding process relative to one another. This can be useful in assessing field trends and understanding where to focus efforts to increase outreach or build capacity.

Data Categories:

- Artistic Discipline
- Operating Budget
- Facility Information
- Crisis Impact

Artistic Discipline | Collected by all 15 agencies

Artistic discipline is often used to group applicants together for comparison (e.g., number of music grantees vs. number of visual arts grantees).

Collection Note: Most agencies collect this on the application, using a dropdown box with standard categories for ease of analysis. The below sample list is from the *National Standard for Arts Information Exchange*:

Discipline: A descriptor designed to enable an agency to select particular groups of constituents by their primary area of work in the arts. Agencies desiring to use more than one discipline code may do so provided one category or subcategory is primary. The primary classification resides in a field labeled "Discipline." All others can be stored in fields labeled "Discipline 2," "Discipline 3," etc.

- | | | |
|-----------------------|-------------------------|---------------------------|
| • Dance | • Design Arts | • Humanities |
| • Music | • Crafts | • Multidisciplinary |
| • Opera/Music Theatre | • Media Arts | • Non-arts/Non-humanities |
| • Theatre | • Literature | |
| • Visual Arts | • Interdisciplinary | |
| | • Folk/Traditional Arts | |

■ **Operating Budget | Collected by All 15 Agencies**

- Operating budget is often used to group applicants together for comparison by budget size (e.g., 75% of funds went to organizations with budgets over \$1M, and 25% went to organizations with budgets under \$1M).
- Budget size is sometimes used to approximate how community-focused an organization is; this is not an exact science, but often smaller organizations are likely to be more localized in their reach than larger.
- Collecting standardized budget breakdowns can also be useful to gauge economic impact of the arts and assess trends in staff/artist pay, amount of money spent on space, and other critical sector information.

Collection Note: Some agencies ask for a budget breakdown as part of their application form (using standardized categories), and others ask for the budget to be attached to the application, with only the Total Operating Budget entered into the form. Collecting standardized budget data makes for easier analysis (e.g., agency staff could easily extract how much their collective grantee pool is spending on staff).

Below are the operating budget categories listed in the *National Standard for Arts Information Exchange*. In addition, some agencies collect information on in-kind contributions and non-operating expenses such as capital acquisitions.

Operating Income

- Admissions
- Contracted Services Revenue
- Other Revenue
- Corporate Support
- Foundation Support
- Other Private Support
- Government Support – Federal
- Government Support – State/Regional
- Government Support – Local
- Applicant Cash

Operating Expenses

- Personnel – Administrative
- Personnel – Artistic
- Personnel – Technical/ Production
- Outside Artistic Fees & Services
- Outside Other Fees & Services
- Space Rental
- Travel
- Marketing
- Remaining Operating Expenses

■ **Facility Information | Collected by 10 of 15 Agencies**

- This data can help gauge an individual organization’s sustainability, and also illuminate trends in the field regarding space availability and accessibility.
- This data may also prove helpful in natural disaster relief efforts.

Collection Note: When this information is collected, it is usually about the grantee’s primary facility, whether it is purely administrative or also programmatic. While many grantees may not own or control their facility, this information can still be valuable in understanding the landscape of cultural space across a city.

Sample types of facility information collected:

- Whether facility is just administrative or also programmatic
- Whether facility is publicly accessible (and number of hours per week open to the public)
- Whether facility is accessible to people with disabilities (i.e., ADA-compliant)
- Whether facility is owned, rented, or donated
- Percent of budget spent on space (sometimes determined from operating budget)

■ **Crisis Impact**

- During times of crisis, whether financial, public health, or natural disaster, having access to data about the impact on organizations can be critical for agencies to determine the focus and scale of their relief efforts. Baseline data can be critical to making a compelling case for help.
- During the Covid-19 crisis in 2020, many agencies asked organizations to estimate the financial impact of the pandemic to get a basic understanding of the scale of the financial need of the sector. During natural disasters, agencies may ask about damage to facilities or storage.
- This information often must be collected in a timely fashion, so sometimes agencies choose to issue a separate survey unless an existing application or final report deadline happens to be timed such that questions can be added to an existing form.

(See the “Collecting Data During a Crisis” spotlight on page 14.)

WORKFORCE & LEADERSHIP

Collecting information about grantee organizations' staff, board, artists, and volunteers can paint a picture of the people involved in providing arts programming across the city.

Data Categories:

- Staff
- Board
- Artists
- Volunteers

■ Staff | Collected by All 15 Agencies

- Collecting numbers and/or categories of staff can be useful to get a sense of the creative workforce.
- Cross-referencing this information with personnel costs from the operating budget breakdown can add another layer of nuance, particularly in terms of measuring economic impact.

Collection Note: Many agencies just ask for the total number of paid staff, though that does not provide nuance on the kinds of staff involved. Some agencies ask for a part-time vs/ full-time breakdown, or for a "Full-Time Equivalent" (FTE) count. Some ask for staff breakdown by administrative, artistic, or technical. (See page 65 for collecting workforce demographics.)

■ Artists | Collected by 13 of 15 Agencies

- Many agencies use the number of artists involved as a critical figure in demonstrating impact/reach.
- Since many agencies advocate for fair artist pay, a particular emphasis is often placed on how many artists are paid.

Collection Note: Some agencies only collect the number of paid artists, and others collect the number of artists involved and the % paid.

■ Board | Collected by 14 of 15 Agencies

- Collecting number of board members can be useful to gauge governance.

Collection Note: All agencies ask for a board list, and some separately ask for the number of board members. Some agencies ask for additional board governance information.

Sample types of board governance information collected:

- Term length (average and/or maximum)
- Number of meetings per year
- % contributing
- "Give/get" amount (average and/or minimum)
- Whether there is a Conflict of Interest policy

■ Volunteers | Collected by 12 of 15 Agencies

- The number of volunteers can be useful in understanding involvement beyond paid staff for all organization sizes.

Collection Note: Beyond the overall number of volunteers, it can be hard to collect information about them (such as number of hours, type of work, or demographics), since they often do not have formal relationships with the organization.

LOCATIONS

Collecting geographic data allows agency staff to determine where in the city grantees and their programs are, giving them a sense of where the agency's investments are going. It also allows them to make maps, which can be powerful tools for demonstrating the agency's reach and for assessing equity across neighborhoods.

Data Categories:

- Administrative Location
- Programmatic Locations

■ Administrative Location | Collected by All 15 Agencies

It can be challenging to collect representative numbers for multiple reasons:

- All agencies interviewed collect an address for each grantee. However, the administrative address is not always where the organization runs its programming. For example, a musical ensemble may perform in multiple venues and may use a P.O. Box as its administrative address.
- Making a map of only the headquarters of cultural organizations may miss many actual venues where people are experiencing the arts.

"It's not about where their mailing address is. It could be in a high-rise, but that's not where they're working with kids across the city."

– Barbara Silzle, Executive Director, Philadelphia Cultural Fund

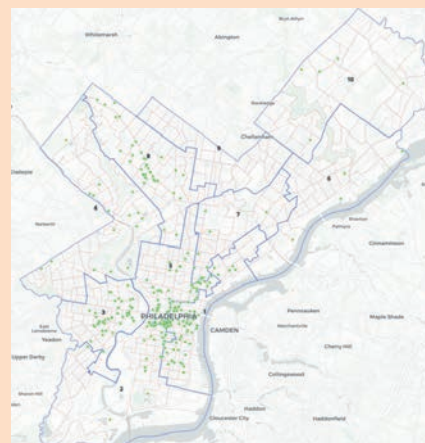
■ Programmatic Locations | Collected by 12 of 15 Agencies

- Many agencies have begun collecting addresses of the sites where grantees provide their programming, which is extremely useful in mapping cultural activities. However, one grantee may have multiple program locations, so it can be a struggle to design a report form that can accommodate varying numbers of addresses per submission.
- Activity location may be a better way of determining level of investment in a particular population than administrative locations, but it still doesn't account for where the program attendees actually come from. A community program might serve primarily people in the immediate neighborhood of the program site, but a museum likely draws people from across the city and beyond. Many institutions conduct periodic surveys of representative samples of attendees to better understand their reach, and that information may be useful for agencies as well.

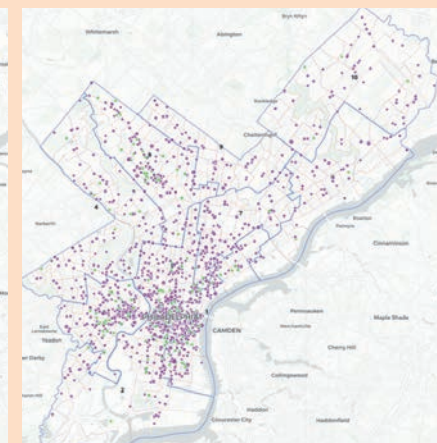
- This metric is less useful for virtual programming, which became especially ubiquitous during the Covid-19 pandemic, as there is not a single representative location where the program took place. Some agencies are collecting information about virtual channels alongside in-person program sites.
- Agencies are beginning to collect more information about program sites, which can be very useful in understanding programming distribution across the city and through virtual channels:
 - Number of activities/occurrences at program site (collected by 4 of 15 agencies)
 - Number of participants/attendees at program site (collected by 2 of 15 agencies)
 - Type of facility at program site (collected by 6 of 15 agencies)
 - Type of activity at program site (collected by 3 of 15 agencies)

Administrative vs. Programmatic Locations

Home Locations:
2019 Art & Culture Grantees



Home and Programming Locations:
2019 Art & Culture Grantees



These two maps compare the administrative and programmatic locations of Philadelphia Cultural Fund grantees, showing that arts activities are occurring in many places outside arts organizations' headquarters.